

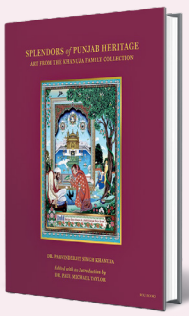
CRIMSON SPRING
by Navtej Sarna
ALEPH
₹**899; 312** pages

The diplomat-author has been an important figure in the landscape of Indian literature. One thinks of Shashi Tharoor and his satirical book *The Great Indian Novel* (1989), of course, but also of A.N.D. Haksar, the brilliant translator of Kalidasa and other Sanskrit stalwarts, the poet Abhay K. and several others. Navtej Sarna, surely the most versatile and prolific writer among this group, has just released his third novel (and ninth book overall) *Crimson Spring*, a powerful reimagining of the Jallianwala Bagh massacre of April 13, 1919, through the eyes of nine characters, two of them British.

Sarna, who retired in 2018 after 36 years in the IFS, had previously written *The Exile* (2008), a poignant, bittersweet novel based on the life of Maharaja Duleep Singh. *Crimson Spring* represents the author at the peak of his powers. Sarna knows when to deploy his wealth of research and domain knowledge—and when to let a more intuitive, poetic style take over the narrative. Like the thrilling first chapter that not only links the nine major characters—ranging from the revolutionary Udham Singh (a "very lightly fictionalised version", according to Sarna) to the Chief Secretary of Punjab—but also does an excellent job of laying out the geography of Jallianwala Bagh and its immediate surroundings (a decision that has a major narrative payoff later in the novel).

Talking about the novel during a Zoom interview, Sarna says: "When I was planning the book, it struck me that it was important for readers to have an overall view of all the major characters. It's unfair if they discover an all-new major character on page 200 or something. As everything in this novel emanates from the Jallianwala Bagh massacre or flows into it, I thought it would be best if I anchored the opening chapter to that day."

The character Hugh J. Porter, Esq. is inspired by the real-life J.P. Thompson but, crucially, Sarna has softened Thompson's



SPLENDORS OF PUNJAB HERITAGE: Art from the Khanuja Family Collection
by Dr Parvinderjit Singh Khanuja
ROLI BOOKS
₹**5,995; 432** pages

PUTTING HIS ART IN THE RIGHT PLACE

Parvinderjit Singh Khanuja's collection of Sikh art is as lavish as the book he has produced

If a resounding rebuff were needed to that old saw that the only culture Punjabis know is agriculture, this book is extravagant proof. Produced in association with the Smithsonian's Asian cultural history programme, it is a lavishly photographed and designed volume of Sikh art—miniatures, weaponry, coins, textiles, photographs and contemporary paintings among other memorabilia—that is the single-handed collection of one individual. Parvinderjit Singh Khanuja, an India-born oncologist who set up a flourishing practice in Phoenix, Arizona, in 1993, pursued his "expensive passion" over 15 years as a form of *seva* (public service), a founding tenet of his faith. His impressive hoard now has a permanent home in the Phoenix Art Museum and, from 2017, is shown in themed exhibitions such as *Virtue and Valour*, *Warriors of World War I* and *The Golden Temple*.

The volume follows a similar structure, though it can feel visually jumpy to find elegant 19th miniatures of Sikh gurus, many in the lyrical Pahari style, bunched with contemporary art by Arpana Caur, the Singh Twins of Liverpool or latter-day postal covers. Two standout early 18th century miniatures, in subject matter and exquisite rendering, are of Sufi mystics Kabir and Mirabai whose verses, included in the sacred *granth*, embody its profoundly secular spirit.

What Dr Khanuja's guided tour of Sikh history may lack in detached scholarship is made up by his enthusiastic buying sprees, resulting in a collection often thinly expansive rather than superlatively refined. Some of its most captivating pieces are from the reign of Maharaja Ranjit Singh (1780-1839). And what relics more alluring than of an empire-builder's meteoric rise, from untutored teenager stricken with smallpox and loss of an eye, to the conquest of realms that extended beyond Punjab to Kashmir and Peshawar.